Regret and Disappointment: Background

Context for annotators, round 2

This document gives you the background you need to code the reviews. Read it once before you start, about 15 minutes. You do not need to read the papers it cites.

1. Two emotions, one difference

Regret and disappointment are both negative feelings about a bad outcome. They differ in **who is to blame**.

- **Regret** is the feeling that you would be better off if you had chosen differently. It needs a choice the person made and now wishes they had not made. Its typical thought is "I should have…" (Zeelenberg et al., 1998a; Zeelenberg & Pieters, 2007).
- **Disappointment** is the feeling that an outcome fell short of what you expected, for reasons outside your control. Its typical thought is "It should have…" (Zeelenberg et al., 1998a; van Dijk et al., 1999).

A person can feel both about the same purchase. The product broke, which is disappointment, and the person also blames themselves for buying the cheap brand, which is regret.

2. Where the difference comes from

Psychologists explain the two emotions by the thoughts that come before them. Weiner (1985) showed that how people explain an outcome shapes the emotion they feel. Regret follows when people see the bad outcome as caused by their own decision and as something they could have avoided. Disappointment follows when they see it as caused by something else: the product, the seller, chance.

Zeelenberg et al. (1998b) found that the two emotions also differ in what people imagine could have gone differently. People recalling a regret mostly imagined changing **their own behavior** ("If only I had set my alarm"). People recalling a disappointment mostly imagined the **situation** being different ("If only the bus had been on time"). These imagined alternatives are called counterfactual thoughts.

Marcatto and Ferrante (2008) found that people cannot reliably name their own feeling as regret or disappointment. Their Regret and Disappointment Scale therefore asks about the thoughts behind the feeling, not the label. We use the same approach: you judge the emotion from what the reviewer says about cause, control and alternatives.

3. How to tell them apart in a review

Look for four cues.

Cue	Points to regret	Points to disappointment
Responsibility: who caused the bad outcome?	The reviewer: their choice, research, order, or use of the product	The product, brand, seller, delivery, or bad luck
Controllability: could the reviewer have prevented it?	Yes: "I could have read the reviews"	No: "There was no way to know it would fail"
Counterfactual: what	Their own behavior: "If only I had	The situation: "If only it had lasted

Cue	Points to regret	Points to disappointment
does the reviewer imagine changing?	bought Duracell"	longer"
Typical words	"I should have", "I wish I had(n't)", "my mistake", "my fault", "lesson learned", "I regret buying"	"It should have", "didn't work", "stopped working", "not as described", "poor quality"

Two common traps:

- **"I" does not mean regret.** "I put them in my remote and they died in a day" is about the product. Regret needs the reviewer to blame their own decision.
- **A plan for next time is not regret on its own.** "Won't buy these again" or "Going with Duracell next time" says what the reviewer will do, not that they blame their past choice. It becomes regret only with self-blame: "I should have stuck with Duracell."

4. What to expect in this data

All reviews come from Amazon customers who rated a product one, two or three stars, mostly for Amazon-brand batteries, Fire tablets and Kindles. When a product fails, most reviewers blame the product, so most reviews will be disappointment. Regret appears when the reviewer turns the blame on their own decision: choosing the cheap option, ignoring warnings, ordering the wrong item. Some reviews are mixed, and some show neither emotion.

Do not let these expectations decide any single review. Code what each text says.

5. Examples

Review	Emotion	Why
"These batteries died in a day."	Disappointment	Blames the product. No alternative imagined.
"It should have worked out of the box."	Disappointment	Imagines the product being different.
"I should have stuck with Duracell."	Regret	Blames the reviewer's own brand choice.
"Terrible decision on my part to trust Amazon to make a decent battery."	Regret	Explicit self-blame for the decision.
"Batteries are junk, and my own fault for going cheap."	Both	Blames the product and the reviewer's choice.
"ok"	Neither	No emotion can be read.

References

Marcatto, F., & Ferrante, D. (2008). The Regret and Disappointment Scale: An instrument for assessing regret and disappointment in decision making. *Judgment and Decision Making*, 3(1), 87–99.

van Dijk, W. W., Zeelenberg, M., & van der Pligt, J. (1999). Not having what you want versus having what you do not want: The impact of type of negative outcome on the experience of disappointment and related emotions. *Cognition and Emotion*, 13(2), 129–148.

Weiner, B. (1985). An attributional theory of achievement motivation and emotion. *Psychological Review*, 92(4), 548–573.

Zeelenberg, M., van Dijk, W. W., Manstead, A. S. R., & van der Pligt, J. (1998a). The experience of regret and disappointment. *Cognition and Emotion*, 12(2), 221–230.

Zeelenberg, M., van Dijk, W. W., van der Pligt, J., Manstead, A. S. R., van Empelen, P., & Reinderman, D. (1998b). Emotional reactions to the outcomes of decisions: The role of counterfactual thought in the experience of regret and disappointment. *Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes*, 75(2), 117–141.

Zeelenberg, M., & Pieters, R. (2007). A theory of regret regulation 1.0. *Journal of Consumer Psychology*, 17(1), 3–18.